



KEEPING IT REAL

THE DOWN PAYMENT WAS NEVER THE HARD PART.

One Realtor's exact fix when a first-time buyer comes up short at closing, not before.

D.J. Paris
Keeping It Real Podcast

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**A BUYER HAD THE
DOWN PAYMENT.
SHE WAS \$4,000
SHORT ON
CLOSING COSTS.**

Alex Maldonado, REALTOR at Circle Real Estate in
Los Angeles, on the gap nobody budgets for.

HIS FIX: STACK A LENDER CREDIT ON TOP OF A SELLER CREDIT.

Maldonado works with a lender who offers lender credits, then writes a seller credit into the same contract. Combined, the two cover a gap a down payment alone never does. "We're getting them lender credits while at the same time writing into the contract that the seller gives the seller credits," he says. "That's basically what we do to get them covered."

MALDONADO'S EXACT SEQUENCE ON EVERY CREDIT-HEAVY OFFER:

- 1 Ask the lender for a credit first.**
It closes part of the gap before the seller is even in
- 2 the conversation.**
- 3 Write the seller credit into the offer as a term, not a request.**
Price the offer a little
- 4 higher to cover it, so the seller's net doesn't drop.**
- 5 Add 3% earnest money if the credit makes the offer look weak.**
It shows the commitment the
- 6 credit alone doesn't.**
- 7 Offer a faster escrow.**
Maldonado's lender can close in 21 days, which matters most to a
- 8 seller who needs the cash fast.**



THE TAKEAWAY

**THE DOWN
PAYMENT GOT HER
IN THE DOOR. THE
CREDITS GOT HER
TO THE TABLE.**

Ask about closing costs on the first call, not the week before closing.